Fading

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/56701207.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra)

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Implied/Referenced Self-Harm, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Domestic Fluff, Fluff and Angst, Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder - PTSD, Human Catra (She-Ra), Catra Needs a Hug (She-Ra)

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by s0ng0fst0rms

Summary

Catra wakes up in the studio apartment she shares with Adora. They are both plagued by the aftermath of war, but through their shared space, their shared life, they slowly start to heal.

Catra woke up in a pile of purple pillows, her back cold with sweat and her mind already racing. After all that had happened, they had decided to move into a small apartment in town, not far from Glimmer's residence. They had had no furniture themselves, so their studio apartment was scarcely filled with what had been gifted to them, and the bed had been brought in straight from Glimmer's home. It was big and soft and filled with many pastel-colored pillows. Usually, they woke up with the pillows surrounding the bed, neither of them accustomed to sleeping with so many of them, and both of them light and restless sleepers, the nightmares of the recent events freshly carved into their minds still. There was much not else in the room, just a small kitchen and a table and two chairs. Catra stretched out her limbs, patted the other side of the bed to find it empty, the duvet neatly tucked into the sides of the bed. Adora had the habit of rising before dawn and going on long runs, the only ways to keep herself safe from the nightmares, from the flashes of the war behind her eyelids, and in the corners of their dark apartment. Catra didn't know exactly the routes Adora ran, or how long she was gone each night. Catra would just wake up at the crack of dawn, in their strange bed, alone. She would always try to close her eyes, turn around and wish for a better dream. For a second of actual rest. She could not remember a time where her muscles had relaxed, her teeth had not grinded together, clamming her jaws. Maybe she had never really felt that way, maybe she had always lived with the feeling that the world could fall apart at a moment's notice. It had always only ever been Adora who could have made her forget for a second, feel less threatened, playing hide and seek in the halls, giggling in stairwells and sneaking into each other's bunkbeds at night.

The memories left a trace of warmth in her heart. She opened her eyes, took in the unfamiliar room, a soft smile growing on her lips. The windows in the studio were facing east, so the morning light brightly covered all the surfaces in the room. There were traces of the two of them scattered across the studio apartment. A sword by the front door in its leather holder, there was no use for it anymore, but it gave them both a safe feeling. There were cups in

the sink, coffee stains from last morning's coffee, their clothes were scattered around the floor, Adora had left this morning by throwing her sleeping shirt on the foot of the bed, Catra's outfit from yesterday was scattered around the room, traces of hastily taking off each other's clothes, a trail from the door to the bed. This made Catra blush, although she would have never admitted that to anyone if there had been anyone with her in the room. But she was trying, trying to be softer, letting in more emotions than just anger. So, she let herself blush while embarrassment settled in her stomach, made her slightly nauseous. The floorboards creaked when she shifted her weight onto her feet and rummaged around the pile of clothes near the bed to find a relatively clean shirt to put on. It was a dark red shirt that had belonged to Adora before- a casual shirt for days off from training, but still in the colors- Catra could hardly finish her own thoughts, the flashes of the barracks, their squadmates, explosions- Her ears started ringing and she let herself sit down right next to the bed, her back to the side of the bedframe. She just needed to breathe. She just needed to breathe.

Still trembling, she regained control over her breathe and her heartrate settled down enough to be able to stand up without feeling like she could pass out at any second. She steadied herself at the counter of their small kitchen, just steps away from the bed, and started busying herself with making coffee. She filled the moka pot with coffee grounds and water, lighted a match to light their burner. The only thing she needed to do was to make coffee, then she would settle in one of the two chairs in their home, at the small round table next to the window, feel the warmth of the morning sun kiss her skin. Soft thoughts. Simple thoughts. The moka pot started sputtering, filling the room with the strong smell of coffee, grounding Catra into the moment. She was making coffee, Adora would be home soon. She opened the doors of the upper cabinets, analyzed the scattering of mismatched coffee mugs. Chose a big white one with simple black letters: Don't talk to me until I've had my coffee. It was one of Adora's thrift store finds. Adora was a self-proclaimed thrift store hater, but once she had seen the eclectic coffee mug collections, she only went in to

collect more mugs for their home, and cutlery. All their kitchenware was mismatched and had been found all over the thrift stores in town.

When Catra was leaning back against the kitchen counter, mug filled with coffee clasped between her hands, her feet warm in the sunlight, the front door opened. Through the creaking of the door sounded Adora, panting. Her hair was tight up in a high ponytail, sweat stood in beads on her forehead. She wore a tank top with low-cut armpit holes, low enough for Catra to be able to see the simple white sports bra underneath. It was paired with a white pair of track pants. Her phone strapped tightly to her biceps. Once she had told Catra that she could always call when she woke up in the morning, alone, she could call to talk about the nightmares, but she had never done that. Catra's own phone still buried under the mountain of purple pillows, turned off or with a dead battery, probably. Stepping inside the room, Catra caught Adora's blue eyes. Again, a blush crept onto Catra's cheeks as Adora smiled at her brightly. Somehow, they had come out of the war, together, and here they now were, girlfriends. Catra looked down at the cup of coffee, her hair too short to hide her blush. The creaking of the floor betrayed Adora's quick approach.
'I just made coffee,' Catra said, gaze still towards the coffee in her own hands, gesturing vaguely towards the burner and the moka pot. They had been through so much, and still confessing her love to Adora had been the most embarrassing thing she had ever done.
'Thank you,' Adora's panting had stopped, her voice instead was soft. Adora blocked the sun on Catra's feet as she stood before her, she lifted the mug from Catra's tight grip and set it down on the counter right next to Catra's hips. 'I'm happy to see you, returning might the best part of my run.' Catra did not respond but her cheeks burned, she wished to fall through the floor, to still be sleeping buried beneath all the purple fluff. How could she have been a determined leader in a war, and now feel so small in her own home, in the presence of her own girlfriend?

Adora stepped even closer, put her hands at Catra's waist and without putting too much pressure on her flesh, lifted her on the

counter. With one hand, Adora tipped Catra's chin slightly up, they were now directly looking at each other. 'Maybe the coffee you make every morning is the best part, the sun flooding our space-' Adora's voice was still soft with a determined edge. She leaned in and kissed Catra, softly, her hands still on Catra's waist. Getting swept up in the feeling, Catra automatically moved her hands to cup Adora's face. She wanted to pull Adora in, keep her this close, always. For the first time that morning, the muscles in Catra's jaw relaxed, she sighed against Adora's lips and disappeared into the kiss. She was just lips against lips, her hands against Adora's sweaty face, Adora's hands in her waist, soft but insisting. Their kiss a mix of strong coffee and the salty taste of sweat lingering on Adora's lips.

When they finally pulled away from their kiss, Catra felt brave enough to look into Adora's eyes. Adora laughed, opened a cabinet right next to Catra's head to get another mug: a blue one that just said 'milk' in white letters. Adora poured hetself the leftover coffee from the moka pot and leaned against the counter, her hips in between Catra's legs.
'At some point you need to stop being embarrassed,' Adora said, 'your whole personality turns around when I enter the room, since- you know.' Adora hesitated, took a sip from her coffee, her gaze wandered away. Catra exactly knew where, to a time where they were both sure they were dying, the last moments of a war.
'I'm trying,' Catra whispered, she laced her fingers through Adora's idle hand that was draped on Catra's lap. 'This is just, so new. I know about fighting, about war strategy. Nobody in the horde told me about love.'
Adora kissed Catra's shoulder: 'I know, I know.' Adora's lips landed on Catra's skin again, this time further down from her shoulder, right where her scars started. Used to wearing long sleeves around others, her uniform always covering her arms, the way Adora did not seem to mind the presence of her scars felt surreal. The fact that Catra could be loved, scarred, possibly a war-criminal- it all felt so unsettling, still. The things they both did to survive, how they almost lost each other, the war caught right in the middle of them. And here they were, the war had ended,

scars healing. The hurt was a part of her body, deeply rooted in a hypervigilance that always kept her on her toes, visible on her scarred arms, a violence she had put onto herself to cope with the violence of others, but here she was. Even though it was all so new, to both of them, Catra was sure that this was it. Love. Like the sun filling the room with bright light. Like the smell of coffee in the morning. The sweaty layer that had formed on Adora's skin from the long run. Glimmer's purple bed. Their belongings scattered about the place, toppling over each other. Their eclectic collection of mugs. Catra was sure.

A/N: This is my first fanfic in a long long time, please be kind!

This one-shot was based on an artwork of ilikeyoucatradora (on instagram)

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!